Refugee Movements: Vietnam 1979-83
A History

1975

In 1975, the Viet Cong took Saigon. It signalled the end of Vietnam's involvement in the complex geopolitics of the Cold War.

1979

Four years later, ethnically charged policies of the regime would force the UNHCR to intervene. They helped people from both South and North Vietnam escape the Viet Cong's oppression.

1979

The displacement crisis would cause around 800,000 people to flee Vietnam. Most ended up in places like the United States and the United Kingdom, and would resettle there permanently.

1979

Yet, the journey to these places was perilous. Travelling by sea, refugees became known as 'boat people'. Without food and water for days, they were at risk of starvation and drowning.

1979

Devastatingly, the 'boat people' were also at risk from pirates arriving with guns. Hanh Tran, who resettled in Wales, described his experience of the arrival of the pirates, as "people started to cry and cry and cry".

1980

At just eight years old, Hong Dam was one of these a 'boat people'. Her Chinese heritage meant that when Vietnamese troops clashed with Chinese troops, life became very difficult for Dam and her family. As employment was withdrawn, they had no choice but to flee, or face starvation.

1996

After settling in the UK and graduating with a BA in Fine Art Sculpture, Dam began working as a Digital Artist. She worked on films such as 'Babe: Pig in the City' and '10,000 BC'.

2013

Following the death of her father and the birth of her daughters, Dam realised that art was her true calling. She began the creation of a visual diary. The piece consisted of her childhood memories, as well as interviews with other refugee children. Her emotive, dream-like images have been displayed in the British Museum.